

POPULATION — THE BASICS

Distribution • Density • Change • Growth • Composition

Component I of Human Geography | Next up: Economic Activities (Primary, Secondary, Tertiary)

- Headings & Definitions ● Explanations ● Highlighter = Key Facts 🎯 Exam Tip ✗ Common Mistake
🧠 Memory Trick

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Page-by-Page



Continuous Scroll



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PATTERN OF POPULATION DISTRIBUTION

Human Geography has several components — the most primary one is **Population**. (The other big component — economic activities: primary, secondary & tertiary — is studied separately.) Let's begin with population distribution.

The **top 10 most populous countries** of the world contribute about **60%** of the world's population — of which **6** are in Asia alone. In simple words: 60 out of every 100 people on Earth live in just 10 countries.

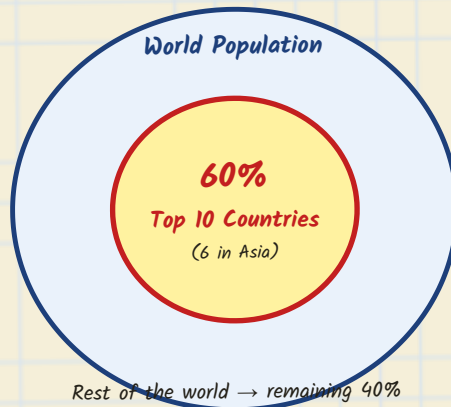


The top three most populous countries are **China, India, and the USA** — and India has now surpassed China to become the most populous country in the world.



Fig 1: 60 out of 100 People Live in 10 Countries





Memory Trick

"60-10-6 Rule" → 60% of population, in 10 countries, of which 6 are in Asia!

What is Population Density?

Population density = how much population lives per unit area, usually expressed as persons per square kilometre.

According to the 2011 Census, India's population density is **382** persons/sq km.

Place	Density (persons/sq km, 2011 Census)
India (average)	382
Bihar (highest among states)	1106
Delhi (highest overall — a Union Territory)	11320
Arunachal Pradesh (lowest)	17

Delhi's density is roughly **10 times** that of Bihar, even though Bihar has the highest density among the states.



Common Mistake

Don't say "Bihar has India's highest density" without qualifying it — Bihar is highest among states, but **Delhi** (a Union Territory) has an even higher density overall.



Exam Tip

Remember the 2011 Census figures as a set: India = 382, Bihar = 1106, Delhi = 11320, Arunachal Pradesh = 17.

📖 Why does density matter for exams? (tap to expand) ▼

Page 1 of 5

← Previous

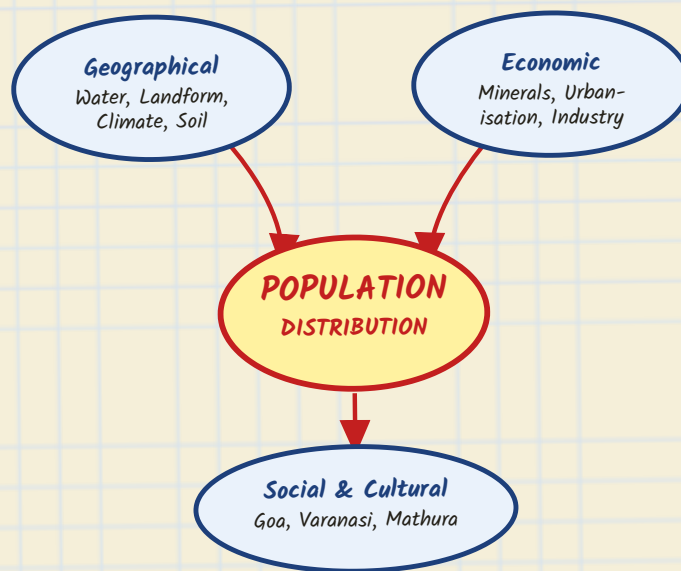
Next →

FACTORS INFLUENCING DISTRIBUTION OF POPULATION

Why is population spread the way it is? Three broad sets of factors decide this: Geographical, Economic, and Social & Cultural factors.

🧠 Fig 2: Factors Affecting Population Distribution –

Mind Map



1 Geographical Factors

- ☕ Availability of water — regions like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal have no water shortage, so they show high population density. Bihar has the highest density on this count, and West Bengal has the second-highest.

- **Landforms** — plain, fertile land (UP, Bihar, Bengal) supports easy transport & agriculture, so people prefer to live there; hilly terrain (Uttarakhand, Ladakh, Jammu & Kashmir) shows much lower density
- **Climate** — extremely hot desert regions (e.g. Africa) have low density; a place with unfavourable climate like **Antarctica** has virtually no population
- **Soil** — the Indo-Gangetic plain has fertile **alluvial soil**, great for cultivation; South India has **red & yellow laterite soil**, which is less fertile



Memory Trick

Geographical factors = **W-L-C-S** → Water, Landform, Climate, Soil.

2 Economic Factors

- **Minerals** — mineral-rich regions like the **Chota Nagpur Plateau** attract population
- **Urbanisation** — cities like **Delhi, Mumbai** show high population due to urban growth
- **Industrialisation** — Mumbai's many industries and company offices pull in migrants seeking jobs

3 Social & Cultural Factors

- **Goa** — a social factor: people go there to socialise (partying and so on)
- **Varanasi** — a cultural factor: people visit for its temples and cultural significance
- **Mathura** — also a cultural factor drawing population/visitors



Common Mistake

Don't assume population distribution is decided by economic factors alone — **geographical** (water, land, climate, soil) and **social-cultural** factors (like Goa's social pull or Varanasi's cultural pull) matter just as much.



Understand it like this...

Think of it as three filters a place must pass to attract people: is the **land** livable (Geographical)? Is there **work** (Economic)? Is there something people **want** to be near — faith, fun, culture (Social & Cultural)?

COMPONENTS OF POPULATION CHANGE

Population of any place changes because of just **three components**: Births, Deaths, and Migration.



Memory Trick

If birth rate = death rate but population is still increasing → there **must** be migration happening. No other explanation is possible!

CBR & CDR

- **Crude Birth Rate (CBR)** — number of live births in a population, usually per 1,000 people
- **Crude Death Rate (CDR)** — number of deaths in a population, again per 1,000 people

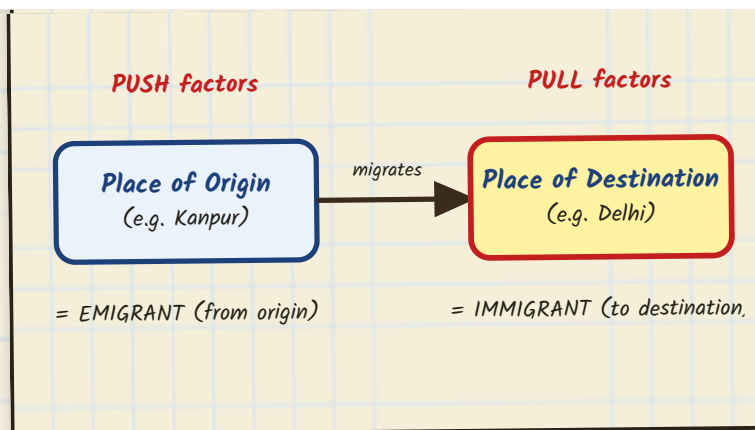
Indicator	India's Value
CBR (Crude Birth Rate)	21.8 per 1,000
CDR (Crude Death Rate, 2011 Census)	7.1 per 1,000

Migration: Origin & Destination

△ Migration always happens from a **place of origin** to a **place of destination**. Example: moving from Kanpur to Delhi → place of origin = Kanpur, place of destination = Delhi. With respect to Kanpur, the person is an **emigrant**; with respect to Delhi, the same person is an **immigrant**.



Fig 3: Migration — Origin → Destination



Push Factors (Origin Becomes Less Attractive)

- Unemployment
- Poor living conditions
- Political turmoil (e.g. the Israel–Palestine region)
- Unpleasant climate
- Natural disasters (e.g. floods in Punjab)
- Epidemics
- Socio-economic backwardness

Example: many Bihar aspirants migrate to Delhi (for IAS preparation) or Kota (for IIT/JEE preparation) because opportunities aren't available while staying in Bihar — that's the unemployment push factor at work.



Current-affairs example

During Bihar's election season, a new party — **Jan Swaraj**, led by **Prashant Kishor (PK)** — has repeatedly pointed out that Bihar shouldn't take pride in producing so many IAS officers and IIT selections, because those successful people are actually *migrants* — they had to leave Bihar (for Delhi's IAS coaching or Kota's IIT coaching) to get selected, since their place of origin (Bihar) couldn't offer them that opportunity.



Real example

During Lalu Prasad Yadav's time, Bihar was seen as having a "gangster rule" — life and property weren't seen as safe, which itself is a push factor (poor security) driving people to migrate out.

Pull Factors (Destination Becomes More Attractive)

- Better job opportunities (e.g. Delhi, Mumbai)
- Better living conditions
- Peace and stability
- Security of life and property
- Pleasant climate (e.g. Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand)
- Other factors, such as lower taxes (e.g. wealthy Indians migrating to the UAE, which has no income tax)

Exam Tip

Push = **origin** becomes unattractive. Pull = **destination** becomes attractive. Same factor (e.g. jobs, climate, safety) can appear on either side depending on which place it is describing!

Common Mistake

Don't confuse **emigrant** and **immigrant** — a single migrating person is an emigrant with respect to the place they left, and an immigrant with respect to the place they arrive at.

Page 3 of 5

← Previous

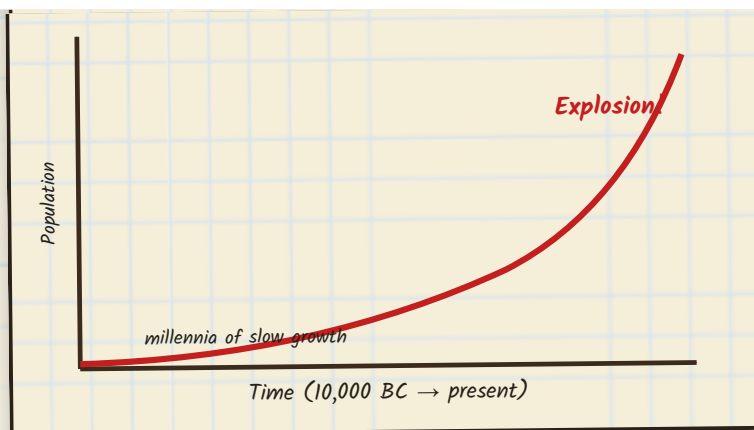
Next →

POPULATION GROWTH TREND + DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

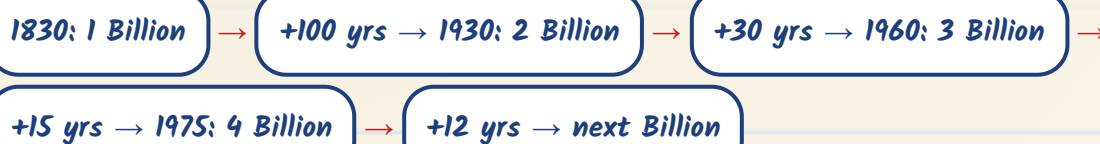
World population growth traces an L-shaped curve — extremely slow for thousands of years, then a sudden explosion. ("12,000 years before present" $\approx$ 10,000 BC, if the present is taken around 2000 AD.)



Fig 4: The L-Shaped Population Growth Curve



It took **millions of years** for humanity to add its first **1 billion** people, reached around **1830**. After that, the pace kept accelerating:



Each successive billion is being added faster than the last — this is what we call a **population explosion**.

Demographic Transition Model (World)

Demographic transition shows how a place's population changes viewed through birth rate and death rate.

- **Stage 1:** Birth rate and death rate are both **high** and roughly equal → population is stagnant. No proper health services, illiteracy, and fast-spreading epidemics keep the death rate high, so people have more children to compensate.
- **Middle stage:** Health conditions and literacy improve → death rate falls sharply, while birth rate stays high → **population explosion**.
- **Last stage:** Both birth rate and death rate become **low** → population is stagnant again — this is the transition from underdeveloped/developing to a developed country.



Memory Trick

Stage 1 = **High-High** (stagnant). Middle = **High-Low** (explosion). Last stage = **Low-Low** (stagnant again).

India's Demographic Transition — 4 Phases

1901 – 1921

Period of Stagnant Population — both birth rate and death rate are high (poor health conditions, illiteracy, epidemics like plague).

1921

Called the "**Year of the Great Divide**" — health conditions improve a little, the death rate starts falling, and steady population growth begins.

1951 – 1981

Population Explosion — independence brings better health conditions and a further fall in death rate; birth rate stays high; on top of that, large-scale migration from Pakistan and Bangladesh adds to the numbers.

1981 – 2011

High growth, but slowing down — rising literacy rates mean the birth/fertility rate is no longer as high, so growth begins to decelerate.



1921 = The Great Divide — where India's population stopped being stagnant!

Population-Controlling Measures

- Access to family planning services
- The **National Family Planning Programme**, implemented in the **Fourth Five-Year Plan**
- Free availability of contraceptives

Thomas Malthus's Theory (1798)

In **1798**, Thomas Malthus proposed that population grows in **Geometric Progression** (exponentially), while food supply grows only in **Arithmetic Progression**.



If population keeps growing faster than food supply, the result is a population crash — through famine, disease, and war.



Common Mistake

Malthus's theory is often filed only under Economics — but it is equally a **Geography/Population** topic, since it directly explains the limits of population growth.

Page 4 of 5

← Previous

Next →



POPULATION COMPOSITION *Dependent vs Working-Age Population*

- **Dependent population:** children aged 0–14 years and elderly aged 60+ years
- **Working-age population:** ages 15–59 years — this is called the **demographic dividend** of a country

The working-age group contributes to a country's economic growth (through work and taxes), while the dependent groups (children & elderly) require government spending on health, education, and pensions.



Memory Trick

0–14 and 60+ = "Dependents" (bookends of life). 15–59 in the middle = the "engine" — the demographic dividend!

Age-Sex Structure & the Population Pyramid

Age-sex structure refers to the number of males and females in different age groups. When plotted, this structure typically takes the shape of a **pyramid**, and a population pyramid reflects the underlying characteristics of a population.

Three Shapes of the Population Pyramid

Shape	What it Means	Examples
Triangular	Population exploding — wide base (many children), narrow top (few elderly)	Kenya, Bangladesh, India
Rectangular	Population stagnant — roughly the same	USA, Australia

width across all age groups

**Inverted
Triangular**

Population declining — narrow base,
broad top (fewer children, more elderly)

Italy, Japan, China (after
the One-Child Policy)

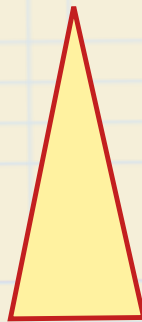


Fig 5: Three Population Pyramid Shapes

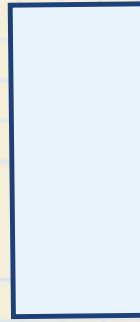
Kenya/Bangladesh/India

USA / Australia

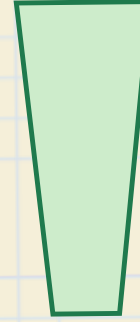
Italy/Japan/China



Triangular



Rectangular



Inv. Triangular

Why does the shape change like this? (tap to expand) ▼

✗ Common Mistake

Don't mix up the "narrow" end — in a **triangular** pyramid the base (bottom, children) is **wide** and the top (elderly) is **narrow**; in an **inverted triangular** pyramid it's the exact opposite: base narrow, top broad.

🎯 Exam Tip

Learn the shape-country pairing directly: **Triangular** → Kenya, Bangladesh, India;
Rectangular → USA, Australia; **Inverted Triangular** → Italy, Japan, China.

★ Exam-Ready Summary

- **Top 10 countries** = 60% of world population, 6 in Asia; top 3 = China, India, USA
- **India's density (2011)**: 382/sq km overall; Bihar highest among states (1106); Delhi highest overall (11320); Arunachal Pradesh lowest (17)
- **3 components of population change**: Births, Deaths, Migration
- **CBR (India)**: 21.8 per 1,000 | **CDR (India, 2011)**: 7.1 per 1,000
- **India's 4 demographic phases**: 1901–21 (stagnant) → 1921 (great divide) → 1951–81 (explosion) → 1981–2011 (slowing growth)

- **Malthus (1798):** population grows geometrically, food grows arithmetically
- **3 pyramid shapes:** Triangular (exploding), Rectangular (stagnant), Inverted Triangular (declining)

Page 5 of 5

← Previous

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